

Semiotics In Grammar: Punctuation Marks In Perspective

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Abstract

Within the realm of conventional writing or written communications, signs and symbols are diligently deployed to make meanings clearer so as to avert ambiguities and superfluities that are capable of hindering a free-flow of information and communication. Whenever these semiotic objects (signs and symbols) are misused, misapplied or abused, there is a tendency to have a miscommunication or misinformation. In most severe cases, they constitute what, technically, we refer to as grammatical noise within the communication value chain. The grammar of any language is a core unit of such a language. As an aspect of linguistic studies, semiotics has gained currency through the scholarly works of Ferdinand de Saussure (Semiology: signifier and signified) and boosts from Charles Sanders Peirce (founder of semiotics through his triadic typology of a sign, object and an interpretant). C.S. Peirce hinged his studies on logic and pragmatist philosophy. As a logician, he subcategorises a sign into three: iconic signs (resemblance or lookalikeness of a signifier and the signified), indexical signs (cause and effect relationship between a signifier and the signified) and lastly, a symbolic sign (which deals with arbitrary relationships and conventions within cultural contexts where such symbols are put into use). The thrust of this paper is to examine or study the use of punctuation marks (mechanics or writing) as one of the core areas of grammar in both spoken and written expressions. Although they are arbitrary in nature, conventionality has blended them into a make or mar situation. When their rules are discarded or downplayed, they thwart meanings and cause confusion everywhere.

Keywords: Sign, symbols, semiotics, semiosis, semiology, punctuation marks, grammar

INTRODUCTION

Semiotics, an aspect of linguistic investigation and communication (nonverbal type), has occupied a significant space in these areas. Scholarly speaking, Ferdinand de Saussure (father of modern linguistics) and Charles Sanders Peirce (father of semiotics) laid the solid foundation upon which the structures of semiotics are erected today. In a book published posthumously and entitled *A Course in General Linguistics* (1916), Ferdinand de Saussure's seminar or lecture notes were collated by his students. This text announced the formal evolution of modern linguistics. De Saussure identifies "langue" and "parole", "signifier" and "signified" which form fulcrums of his semiology – a study of signs used in language.

Ferdinand de Saussure's semiology gains prominence through scholarly works by Charles Sanders Peirce (1839 – 1914), an American philosopher (Abrams 289). Another famous scholar, in this area, is an English Philosopher – John Locke, who coined "semiotic" in the early 17th century. It is noteworthy that philosophers have keen interest in the study of semiotics. McArthur confirms this as he states:

The study and analysis of signs and symbols as part of communication, as for example in language, gesture, clothings and behavior in present-day semiotics arises from the independent work of two linguistic researchers, one in the U.S, the other in Switzerland. Charles S. Pierce (1834 – 1914) used the term to describe the study of signs and symbolic systems from a philosophical perspective while Ferdinand de Saussure (1857 – 1913) coined semiology as part of his interest in language as a system of signs (835)

From this point of view of McArthur, it has become imperative to note that semiotics or semiology forms an integral part of the communication network which language is a chief tool or instrument. Other forms of nonverbal expression or communication such as body language, paralanguage, signs and symbols, could be considered as parts and parcels of semiotic concerns. Semiotic investigations or analyses bother on how signs and symbols can be used for effective communication.

In his work, "Ancient Semiotics," Giovanni Maneth reviews some earliest or ancient manifestations of semiotics in Europe or the West. According to Maneth:

... the aim here, therefore, is to investigate both semiotic practices from their origins (as divination and medicine) and the theoretical considerations of signs which were developed in the ancient world, and which have come down to us through the literary, philosophical, medical, historical and rhetorical tradition. We might thus rediscover a thread which may be traced through classical world from its origins to the fourth century AD, revealing a conception of the sign which is significantly different from that proposed in the twentieth century (13)

From Maneth's stance, the earliest manifestations of semiotic studies during classical era were through human acts of divinations and medicine as practised then. Some evidence abound in the following areas: Mesopotamian divination, Greek divination, Greek medicine, Plato (427 – 347 BCE), Aristotle (384 – 323 BCE), the Stoics, Epicurus (342 – 271 BCE), Philodemus (circa 110 – 40 or 35 BCE), Latin Rhetoric, Augustine (AD 354 – 430) (Maneth 13 – 28).

Some notable semioticians who have contributed immeasurably to the study of semiotics include Rudolph Carnap (1891 – 1970), Umberto Eco (1932 – 2016), Saint Augustine of Hippo (354 – 430), Charles W. Morris (1901 – 1979), Thomas A. Sebeok (1920 – 2001), Paul Bouissac, Julia Kristeva, Yuri Lotman, Roland Barthes among many others.

As a scientific study of signs, signaling systems and symbols used for communication, semiotics has a multidisciplinary dimension, which interfaces with other areas of human endeavours. This age long nexus between semiotics and other areas gave rise to a plethora of subfields of semiotics such as: marketing/commercial semiotics, semiotics of law or legal semiotics, visual semiotics, social semiotics, cultural semiotics, pictorial semiotics, semiotics of dreaming, design semiotics, musical semiotics, organisational semiotics, theatre semiotics, semiotics of photography, urban semiotics, artificial

intelligence semiotics, zoo semiotics, finite semiotics, cognitive semiotics among many others (Daniel Eluke, "Unpublished PhD Thesis").

However, it becomes instructive to note, at this point, that punctuation marks are considered as symbolic signs (semiotic objects) in grammar or any other spoken or written communication where they can be applied, employed or deployed for clarity of meanings and purposes to curtail linguistic infelicities such as ambiguities, superfluities and many others. In underscoring the relevance of these symbolic signs (punctuation marks) in grammar, Nzebunachi Oji cited in Joy Eyisi, states clearly:

... sound grammar and spelling are not the only requirements of a good composition. The sentence must be punctuated. A badly punctuated piece of writing distorts the meaning that the author intends to convey to the reader. A good command of the use of punctuation marks gives lustre, perspicuity and vividness to an essay (qtd in Odeh 155)

The excerpt above summarises the overwhelming role of punctuation marks in compositions. Again, Odeh notes with emphasis that punctuation marks are mainly used for two reasons: (1) because meaning demands it and (2) because conventional usage requires it. Punctuation [symbolic sign] makes the meaning of a sentence clear (157)

GRAMMAR

This core area of linguistic analysis has been misunderstood, misinterpreted, or better still, misused and abused over time by some professionals and non-professionals. Some conceive it as a book on any language, while others conceptualise it to be a combination of morphology (study of internal structures of words or anatomy of words/morphemes) and syntax (a study of larger grammatical constructions or structures higher than words and the rules governing them in meaning-making).

In this paper, grammar is conceived as an innate knowledge which resides in a mind of a competent speaker of a language. This knowledge covers both oral and written languages of the world. To know a grammar of a language is quite different from the use of such language. In this case,

communicative competence (usage) far outweighs linguistic or grammatical competence (grammar). In the English language, one of the core areas, which either makes or mars any form of discourse (oral or written) is a misapplication of mechanics of writing or punctuation marks as case may be. These markers (symbolic signs) are arbitrary but, conventionally, used in communication.

Chioma Opara notes that:

Grammar, punctuation and mechanics are the three basic components of effective writing. Mechanics essentially deals with the spelling, appearance and arrangement of words in a text... conventions of writing demand correct punctuation. Punctuation could be mechanic or stylistic, it may depend on the author's choice or creative writing. Punctuation marks are used to indicate pauses, change of tone or thought flow as well as introducing words. They not only give meaning to a piece of work, but also guide the reader (27)

What Opara captures, here, is the whole essence of semiotic symbols or symbolic signs in grammar. They enhance meaning and direct the thoughts of language users.

SEMIOTICS AND GRAMMAR

This subsection delves into an exhaustive analysis of the use of punctuation marks (in the sense of semiotic signs) in grammar, especially, written communications. Below is a diagrammatic representation of punctuation marks used in the English language (grammar).

PUNCTUATION MARKS AS SEMIOTIC SIGNS

Figure 1: Punctuation Marks (Classification)

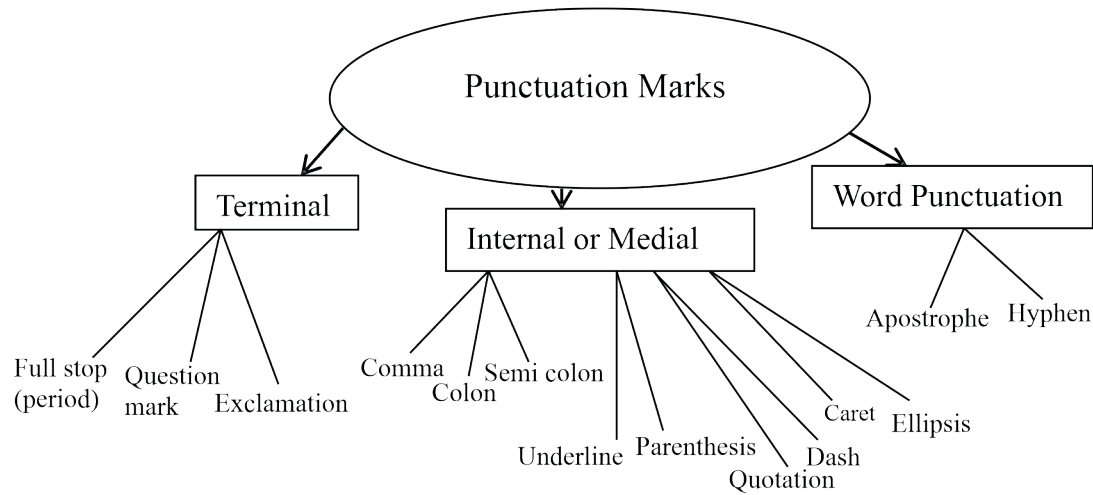


Figure 2: Semiotic Signs in English

Symbols in English				Punctuation Marks in	
 Plus	 Minus	 Divide	 Multiply	Comma	(,)
 Percent	 Equal	 Pi	 Square root	Full Stop	(.)
 Plus-minus	 minus -plus	 Parentheses	 Brackets	Slash	(/)
 Not equal	 Greater than	 Less than	 Sum of	Semicolon	(;)
 Beta	 Alpha	 Integral	 Empty set	Quotation Mark	(" ")
 Because	 Therefore	 Infinity	 Asterisk	Question Mark	(?)
				Parentheses	(())
				Hyphen	(-)
				Exclamation Mark	(!)
				Ellipsis	(...)
				Colon	(:)
				Square Bracket	([])
				Curly Brackets	({ })
				Apostrophe	(')
				Percent	(%)
				And	(&)
				Greater Than	(>)
				Less than	(<)
				At the rate sign	(@)
				Equal	(=)
				Hash	(#)
				Underscore	(_)
				Bar	()

However, let us make some insightful deliberations on the usefulness or relevance of these markers in both spoken and written communications in the English Language. The pauses are considered as terminal points or pauses because they occur at the end of sentences and are followed by the upper case letters thereafter.

Onyeakusi (43) identifies three types of punctuation: end punctuation [terminal pauses, internal or medial punctuation and word punctuation (qtd in Odeh 158). It is worthy of note that the first classification, here, is same as terminal points or pauses. The internal or medial punctuation includes the comma, the colon, the semi-colon, the ellipsis, the dash, the caret, the quotation marks, the parenthesis, the underlying and the pointer. All these could be applied or used within or in middle of sentences, and other larger constructions (phrases and clauses) in a composition. Besides, the word punctuation marks are the apostrophe and the hyphen.

The Full Stop or Period [.]

The full stop or period is used to mark an end of a declarative sentence as this does not apply to such sentences which require a question mark or an exclamation mark. According to Glory Worukwo... "the full stop represents the greatest pause and separation in written language" (118). In other words, the full stop is the longest pause in the cause of reading. Some examples include:

- (1) Ngozi is my wife.
- (2) I killed a snake.
- (3) There was no contentious issue.

The full stop is also used for abbreviations and initialisms. Instances include: Prof. Ph.D., P.M. Rev., Jan., A.M., B.A, M.A, e.g. Sen. Etc. and many others. However, in contemporary English, the full stop is omitted in common, well-known abbreviations and acronyms such as BBC, USA, UN, UNESCO, WAEC, RSU, UNIPORT, NEPA, NAFDAC, INEC, UPTH, PHC – all regarded as full spellings. Furthermore, abbreviations that involve the first and last letters of a word may or may not take a full stop. Some examples abound: Mr. or Mr, Dr. or Dr, Mrs. Or Mrs,. It is noteworthy that when an abbreviation occurs at the end of a sentence, only one full stop is taken.

- (1) Masirimchi saw Prof.

- (2) Our meeting started at 5pm.

The full stop is also in dominant use in internet and email addresses. Here are some salient examples: www.rsu.edu.ng, elukedaniel9@gmail.com and many others, where the full stop is christened "dot". It is also used in units of money, measurement and time written in figures: N5000.00, 9.45pm., 12.8metres. Sentences which end in ellipses often take a fourth dot which is a full stop.

The Question Mark [?]

This punctuation mark is also known as the query. It is used at the end of every direct, rhetorical and tag questions. The question mark is also used at the end of declarative and imperative sentences that are converted into questions. However, indirect questions, often, take the full stop. Instances abound in the following ways:

- (1) What is your age?
- (2) Sail to the sea?
- (3) Urudinichi asked whether Chituga would accept it?
- (4) Blessing asked if I had left?
- (5) Auntie Chidi visited me?

The Exclamation Mark [!]

This is used to end any word, phrase, sentence which expresses a sudden emotional feeling of anger, surprise, fear, doubt, joy, shock, etc. Besides, it is used to indicate any surprise or raised tone of voice. Examples: Oh! Gosh! Pooh! Wow! What a blessing! Marvelous ancestors!

Internal or Medial Punctuation

The internal punctuation is also known as the medial mark because the punctuation marks are used within sentences or between words, phrases, clauses and sentences. They include: the comma, colon, semi-colon, dash, brackets, inverted commas or quotation marks, ellipsis, caret etc. Of all of them, the comma, colon and semi-colon are the most troublesome. However, the comma is still more troublesome and, often, abused or misused by students and many uninformed second language users of English more than other internal punctuation marks.

The Comma [,]

This punctuation mark is used in the following ways:

- (1) The comma is used to separate items in a list. E.g. Ngozi bought a radio, a

- Peugeot 504 car, a fridge, and a generator set.
- (2) To separate phrases or clauses in a sentence. E.g. If Masirimchi remains patient, minds her business and works hard, she can still make it.
 - (3) The comma is also used to mark off or separate a subordinate clause beginning a sentence. Examples:
 - (a) Because she is a student, Uru reads every day.
 - (b) As we were going, we saw the terrorist gang.
 - (4) The comma is also used to mark off nouns, pronouns and noun phrases in non-restrictive appositions. Some examples are:
 - (a) The former Minister of Transportation, Rt. Hon Chibuike Rotimi Amaechi, visited China last year.
 - (b) Dr. Daniel Eluke, the author of "Semiotics in Grammar", is a lecturer in English.
 - (5) It is used to mark off transitional words and phrases such as in fact, however, therefore, indeed, of course, for instance, for example, in addition, furthermore, nevertheless, etc.
 - (6) It is used also to introduce a quotation such as: Nkiru asked Okwu, "Must I pay the money in the bank"?
 - (7) The comma is used to separate a tag question from the rest of the sentence: (a) We cannot go now, can we? (b) You live at Elu Kingdom, right?
 - (8) The comma is also used to separate or mark off an adverb or adverbial that begins a sentence. For instance:
 - (a) Truly, Yelwata is a place of hopelessness and lifelessness.
 - (b) At the school gate, we met each other.
 - (9) The comma is used to separate "yes", "no", "too", etc.
 - (a) Yes, she is a thief.
 - (b) No, I don't know them.
 - (c) I, too, warned him.
 - (10) It is also used to separate participial phrases. E.g.,
 - (a) Having watched the match, I felt so disappointed with the team.
 - (11) The comma is used to mark off a surname that appears before other names. E.g.
 - (a) Eluke, Daniel Henacho
 - (b) Ngulube, Isaac Eyi
 - (c) Henacho – Eluke, Ngozi

- (12) It is also used to mark off an addressee – to separate the vocative from the rest of the sentence. E.g.
- (a) You can come in, Chituga
 - (b) Didia, let us see later
 - (c) Prof, Burabari has come
 - (d) We can say, madam, that women are more powerful than men etc.
- Lastly, commas are used for brief pauses. They should not be used to join independent or main clauses, not to separate a subject from its verb, and equally not to separate its verbs from its object.

The Colon [:]

This punctuation mark is used in the following ways:

- (1) The colon is used to introduce a list of items. E.g. Ngozi bought many items: garri, beans, rice, plantain, pepper and salt
- (2) It is also used to introduce a direct quotation, proverb, a speech. E.g. William Shakespeare says: “The world is a stage”.
- (3) It is equally used in front of a phrase or a clause which explains the previous idea. In other words, it shows that another remark follows the first part of a sentence. E.g.
 - (a) The reason for the mass failure of students in GST 111 is simply this: students are not reading hard.
 - (b) University graduates have many choices of career available for them: they can take white collar jobs, or they can go into private business etc.
- (4) The colon is also used to separate the hour from the minute and in Bible references to separate the chapter from the verse. E.g, Psalm 104:14-15, Ecclesiastes 2:24, 12:30pm etc.

The Semi-colon [;]

This is a stronger punctuation mark than the comma, hence, it is also called a weak period (Worukwo 116). It is used in the following ways:

- (1) It is used to join main clauses that are not joined by a conjunction. E.g, the chairman has come; you may go in.
- (2) The semi-colon is also used to separate a series of items that are separated by commas. E.g, B.A. English Studies, UPH; M.A. English, UPH; PhD, RSU etc.

The Caret [^]

This is the punctuation mark which indicates that an omission by mistake has occurred in the course of writing. When a letter, word, phrase etc. is mistakenly omitted, the caret is inserted at the point of the omission and the omitted letter, word etc is inserted above. E.g. (1) I missed flight (2) I missed ^{my} flight.

The Ellipsis [...]

The ellipsis or elliptical dot is inserted to indicate a deliberate omission in a direct quotation. It, usually, takes three dots used to remove an irrelevant part of a quotation. For example, I saw Chidugam who came with his wife at the stadium. I saw Chidugam... at the stadium. The ellipsis may be used, but the complete statement or sentence must be maintained and not to give an incomplete sentence or sentence fragment. The ellipsis is also used to indicate a thought expressed hesitantly (Odeh 165)

The Dash [-]

This is a short line but it is longer than a hyphen. It is used for clarity and emphasis. It is used for different purposes:

- (1) It is used to introduce an after thought. E.g. He has a PhD – or so he claims.
- (2) It is used to show that what follows is summary or conclusion of what has been said for example, honesty, love, patience, humility – those virtues of a humanist.
- (3) The dash is also used to indicate an abrupt and a sudden change in thought. E.g, I was drinking – who is here?
- (4) It is used to repeat a word or phrase in order to emphasize or clarify it. E.g, Human beings enjoy world pleasures – worldly pleasures that are taken them to nowhere.
- (5) The dash is also used to enclose or separate parenthetical statement from the main one. E.g, Ibekwe won the prize – and forgot everybody in the family – and died there etc.

The Quotation Marks [“ ”]

The quotation marks are also called inverted commas. They are used to enclose direct quotations alone and not indirect quotations or paraphrases. When someone else's exact words are borrowed, you insert the quotation marks at the back and front of the words, phrase, clause or sentence borrowed. Quotation

marks come to life in direct speeches. However, they are not used in invented or block quotations. Examples of direct speeches that require the quotation marks or inverted commas are:

- (a) Dr. Eluke said: "A struggle of womanhood is akin to a struggle of nationhood".
- (b) Bethuel Amadi said: "Every woman is a trickster"
- (2) Quotation marks are used to enclose the title of books, articles, magazines, films, music, poems, stories etc. E.g,
 - (a) "The Agony of Nwanyinma" is an interesting short story.
 - (b) Daniel Eluke's "Hypocrisy" is about the worrisome level of hypocrisy that characterizes our national polity.
- (3) The quotation marks are used to call or draw attention to a word that is unusual for the context it is used. It may be a borrowed word, slang, coinage or the word is used in a special sense. E.g., (1) It was a case of another "Chibok" in our nation.
- (4) Quotation marks are usually double. However, if the quotation appears within a quotation, it is usually single. E.g, In his exact words, Chinua Achebe thunders: "Nigeria is doomed because of towering corruption, 'the fastest growing industry' and may go into extinction in coming days".
- (5) The quotation marks are usually used to enclose letters referred to as letters. E.g, letter "b" is thicker than the letter "p" in shorthand.

The Parenthesis () or [] or { }

This punctuation mark is also called brackets. It is in different shapes and named in accordance with the shape: round brackets () (), square brackets ([]) or brace brackets ({ }) – all for different functions and purposes. The round brackets are the most common type of parenthesis. Parenthesis is used to separate or enclose an extra or additional information or a comment from the rest of the sentence whose removal does not affect the correctness and meaning of the original sentence. The information enclosed is called a parenthesis, while the pair of brackets enclosing it is known as parentheses (Eyisi 245) (qtd in Odeh 168). Brackets like commas, and dashes interrupt the flow of the main sentence. E.g,

- (a) F.A. Uchegbu has been called to the Bar (that was all her ambition) and a practising lawyer now.
- (1) The round brackets are also used to enclose cross – references and

- bibliographic references. E.g, semiotics is the scientific study or systematic study of signs and signaling systems (Daniel Eluke 33)
- (b) Figurative expressions are cosmetics to good writing (see chapter seven)
 - (2) The parentheses are also used to enclose numbers and letters in a text. For example, His plans for the term are (i) to finish school (ii) marry (iii) get a well-paid job.
 - (3) Brackets are also used to enclose abbreviations that follow spelled-out forms that follow abbreviations. E.g,
 - (a) The United Nations (UN) meets in Abuja next week.
 - (b) I attended last years conference of the ELTAN (English Language Teachers Association of Nigeria).
 - (4) They are used to enclose definitions or translations in the main part of a sentence. E.g,
 - (a) Creative writers, often, write *ex nihilo* (out of nothing)
 - (b) Chituga bought some pieces of furniture (tables, chairs, cupboards, wardrobe).
 - (5) The parentheses are also used to indicate alternative terms. For example, I meant to see the character(s) features in the play.
 - (6) They are equally used to enclose quotations that support or illustrate a statement in the main sentence. E.g, (a) Ebere, the village virgin has been put on a family way by his teacher (“All that glitters is not gold”).
 - (7) Lastly, parentheses are used to enclose in figure amounts of money and numbers spelled out in the main sentence. E.g, (i) Emeka paid me the sum of twenty thousand naira only (N20,000), (ii) Lawrence sold ten (10) copies of the paper.

The square brackets ([]) are used to enclose information already enclosed in round brackets as in (Plato [480-650]) was a contemporary of Aristotle. Square brackets are also used for editorial commands, while the brace brackets are used more in scholarly or technical contexts.

The Underlining (_)

This punctuation mark is used as a substitute for italics. It is intended to draw attention or for emphasis. Underlining or italics is used to show titles of books, magazines, journals, etc. E.g. An Advanced English Grammar and Composition. The underlining or italics is also used for words of foreign origin. However, the quotation marks can also serve this purpose.

The Pointer (; -)

This is used to introduce a list or examples. It performs the same function like the colon. For example, I shall buy the following: - eggs, plates, books and shares.

The Word Punctuation Marks

These are punctuation marks used within words – either to join syllables of a word, join two words together or to indicate the genitive case in nouns. The word punctuation has two types: apostrophe and hyphen.

The Apostrophe (')

This punctuation mark normally goes with the “-s” morpheme. It is used to indicate possession or ownership in nouns and indefinite pronouns, E.g, John's car, mother's house, the boys' parents, anybody's case, Moses' laws, Lawson's books. The apostrophe and the “- s” ('s) morpheme are used for both singular and plural possessions in nouns. In the singular possession, you affix the apostrophe plus the “- s” morpheme as in mother's house, John's car. However, to show plural possession, you only affix the apostrophe without any additional “- s” morpheme as in students' results, farmers' loans, five days' duration. In another development, the nouns get their plural forms without the inflection of the “- s” can take the apostrophe plus their's' to indicate a plural possession as in children's toys, people's destinies, men's means etc. There is an exception here. The technicality in the apostrophe with common nouns and proper nouns that originally ends with an “- s” morpheme such as Jesus, Moses, boss, class, cactus, canvas, Texas, Lucas, Gallas, lens, bus, Festus, Wales have a different way of admitting the “- s” morpheme. In usage, all the words enumerated can take the 's' morpheme to make possession or ownership but in exception of Jesus and Moses.

- (2) The apostrophe is also used to make omission of letters in contractions, e.g. don't', can't, haven't.
- (3) They can as well be used to form plural of letters, numerals and abbreviations. E.g, (i) Cross your t's and dot your i's (ii) six 10's, three 5's (iii) two DVD's
- (4) The apostrophe also shows the omission in deletion of digits in numerals. E.g, (i) Soccer in the 80's etc.

The Hyphen (-)

The hyphen is a shorter line than the dash. It is used to join composite or compound words – from two or more words. E.g, passer-by, kind-hearted, sister-in-law, old-fashioned. However, we must not break parts of compound words that are in their rights such as “the-rapist”, “mans-slaughter” as this misleads and confuses the reader (Eyisi 253) (qtd in Odeh 173)

- (1) The hyphen is also used to break or divide a word into two at the end of lines. It is not put at the beginning of the word but before the remaining part of the word carried over to the next line. One syllable words must never be divided, a syllable must never be separated. Thus, divisions or hyphenations such as bo-y, ma-ke, teach-er etc are all wrong.
- (2) The hyphen is used to separate a prefix that ends with a vowel or a word or root that stands with the same vowel. E.g, re-enact, pre-eminent, co-opt, de-escalate, co-occur, etc.
- (3) The hyphen is also used to separate compound words made with “ex” and “self”. E.g.s, ex-wife, ex-president, self-holy, self-serving, etc.
- (4) It is also used when writing compound numbers between 21 and 99 in words. E.g, twenty-one, thirty-seven, forty-five, ninety-nine.
- (5) The hyphen is also used after the prefix in a proper noun. E.g, pre-Islam, post-colonialism, pro-Biafra, anti-America.
- (6) It is also used to demarcate the prefix and the root to avoid ambiguity. E.g, re-cover, re-count, reform-as recover and reform are words of their own rights and can be confusing if not hyphenated.

IMPLICATIONS FOR COMMUNICATION AND MISCOMMUNICATION

Whenever punctuation marks (semiotic signs) are wrongly applied or misused, there is every tendency to misinform the audience. As the situation arises, effective communication is defeated and miscommunication saps in.

These semiotic signs used in grammar usually embarrass second language users or learners who are yet to familiarise themselves with the workings of these signs or symbols used in grammar. Some linguistic infelicities such as ambiguity, superfluity, tautology, redundancy and many others rear their ugly heads mostly when punctuation marks are wrongly employed either in oral presentations or written communications.

Treating punctuation as semiotic objects offers valuable insights into how

meaning is constructed and negotiated in language. by analyzing punctuation marks as signs, researchers can better understand their role in conveying intended meaning and shaping the recipient's interpretation. These are some key aspects to this discussion and they include: signification – when punctuation marks can be seen as signs that carry specific meaning, influencing how text is interpreted; contextual influence – the meaning of punctuation marks can vary depending on the context in which they are used; cultural variations – punctuation marks have different meanings in places or cultures and lastly, communication effectiveness – by studying punctuations as semiotic objects, researchers can gain insights into how to improve communication effectiveness.

Analysing punctuation as semiotic objects can deepen our understanding of language and meaning – making processes. These can also assist in shaping meaning which researchers can develop for effective communication strategies. It could provide valuable insights into cultural differences and nuances in communication.

This research is applicable in Discourse Analysis (how to apply semiotic analysis to study the rule of punctuation in shaping discourse and meaning), language teaching (understanding punctuation as semiotic objects can inform language teaching practices, helping learners to develop more effective communication skills), communication studies (semiotics can be applied to study the rule of punctuation in various forms of communication, including advertising, journalism and social media).

Semiotics reveals that punctuation marks are more than just grammatical symbols; they convey meaning, tone, and context to the reader. By analyzing punctuation as signs, researchers can better understand how they shape the interpretation of texts.

CONCLUSION AND CONTRIBUTION TO KNOWLEDGE

From every available information contained, here, this paper conceives punctuation marks as symbolic signs that are used in languages (in this case, English). The attempt is to draw attention of our audience that punctuation marks are overwhelmingly useful or important for anybody to achieve effective communication. Whenever the punctuation marks are wrongly

applied, they distort meaning, thereby, hindering information flow and causing miscommunication. This could lead to meaning crises and misinterpretations which engender rift, rancour and in most severe cases, conflicts that could trigger off wars.

These punctuation marks could be very troubling to some uninformed second language users or greenhorns in the field. This paper advocates that scholars and non-scholars alike pay particular attention in the study of these semiotic signs – symbols – in grammar as they could make or mar our communication. As researchers, you discard or downplay their roles at your own peril. They assist language users to say what they mean and mean what they say.

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